

dangerous to society. They mean well, but, invoking my Bastiat argument of [Chapter 8](#), they are a threat to us. They are wasting our studies of uncertainty by focusing on the insignificant. Our resources (both cognitive and scientific) are limited, perhaps too limited. Those who distract us increase the risk of Black Swans.

This commoditization of the notion of uncertainty as symptomatic of Black Swan blindness is worth discussing further here.

Given that people in finance and economics are seeped in the Gaussian to the point of choking on it, I looked for financial economists with philosophical bents to see how their critical thinking allows them to handle this problem. I found a few. One such person got a PhD in philosophy, then, four years later, another in finance; he published papers in both fields, as well as numerous textbooks in finance. But I was disheartened by him: he seemed to have compartmentalized his ideas on uncertainty so that he had two distinct professions: philosophy and quantitative finance. The problem of induction, Mediocristan, epistemic opacity, or the offensive assumption of the Gaussian—these did not hit him as true problems. His numerous textbooks drilled Gaussian methods into students' heads, as though their author had forgotten that he was a philosopher. Then he promptly remembered that he was when writing philosophy texts on seemingly scholarly matters.

The same context specificity leads people to take the escalator to the StairMasters, but the philosopher's case is far, far more dangerous since he uses up our storage for critical thinking in a sterile occupation. Philosophers like to practice philosophical thinking on me-too subjects that other philosophers call philosophy, and they leave their minds at the door when they are outside of these subjects.

The Problem of Practice

As much as I rail against the bell curve, Platonicity, and the ludic fallacy, my principal problem is not so much with statisticians—after all, these are computing people, not thinkers. We should be far less tolerant of philosophers, with their bureaucratic apparatchiks closing our minds. Philosophers, the watchdogs of critical thinking, have duties beyond those of other professions.

HOW MANY WITTGENSTEINS CAN DANCE ON THE HEAD OF A PIN?

A number of semishabbily dressed (but thoughtful-looking) people gather in a room, silently looking at a guest speaker. They are all professional philosophers attending the prestigious weekly colloquium at a New York-area